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Deliberations at the Round Table Conferences

IN MAY 1930, THE VICEROY, Lord Irwin, announced a Round Table Conference to be held in London in November of that year. This was in keeping with his statement in October 1929 where he had indicated that the best way of settling the Indian political question was to hold a conference where Indian delegates and British spokesmen would discuss and attempt to find a solution to India's political question. The declared aim was Dominion Status for India.

Throughout the latter half of the 1920s, Indian political sentiment had started to make itself heard. In September 1925, Pt Motilal Nehru had moved an amendment which in effect demanded the convening of such a conference for drawing up a constitutional scheme for India. Purshotamdas had supported this amendment in a telling speech. The British blundered badly when the Simon Commission, which was appointed in November 1927, did not include a single Indian member. The boycott of the Commission is too well-known to bear repetition, but what it did do was to unite, if only temporarily, all political parties and shades of political opinion. In December 1929 the Lahore session of the Congress presided by Pt Jawaharlal Nehru passed a resolution adopting complete independence or *Swaraj*[1] as the political objective of India. A few months later in March 1930, Gandhiji's historic march to Dandi to break the salt law signalled the beginning of another Civil Disobedience movement.

The Congress had refused to attend the Conference since its demand for immediate Dominion Status was not granted. Many Congress leaders were